

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



RINGING IN A NEW YEAR

Lesbian couple makes history as Cook County's first marriage of '26

By Rebecca Johnson | Chicago Tribune

Elizabeth Branske rescheduled her first date with her now-wife, Melissa Nunez, three times before they met up at Emporium Arcade Bar in Logan Square two years ago.

The wait ended up being worth it, though, Branske said. It was the most fun she'd ever had on a first date. Nunez wasn't intimidated by her competitiveness at games, and they stayed up late talking about almost everything. Nunez, meanwhile, felt like she was "floating on clouds" and appreciated Branske seeing through her shyness.

"That's just kind of been our whole relationship, just being able to talk to each other and be open and no judgment," Branske, 27, said.

On Friday morning, Branske and Nunez, 25, became the first couple to marry in Cook County in 2026, a milestone they and their families celebrated with kisses and cheers. Branske wore a red dress and a sparkling ring on her finger, while Nunez donned a coordinating red sweater.

Cook County Clerk Monica Gordon officiated the ceremony at the downtown office, asking them to love, honor and support each other before pronouncing them married. They also shared a toast. The clerk's office is the official record keeper for marriages across the county.

"I believe in love. I believe in forever love," Gordon said. "And I'm looking at you too, and I'm like this is going to last forever."

Nunez applied for the coveted — and competitive — first marriage license as a surprise for Branske. They never thought they would win, though. After all, more than 1,000 Chicago-area couples entered this year's lottery, the highest number of entries ever received.

So it wasn't surprising when another couple initially won the lottery. But when

Turn to Marriage, Page 4

"2026 is supposed to be a year of love and prosperity, so I'm excited to see what it has in store." — Elizabeth Branske, who married Melissa Nunez on Friday

'Just riding the wave'

Arlington Heights teenager among the breakout stars of 'Stranger Things' season

By Tess Kenny
Chicago Tribune

It's been an exciting few weeks for Jake Connelly.

The 13-year-old from Arlington Heights has had the thrill of watching the Chicago Bears — his favorite hometown team — clinch a playoff spot, saw New York City done up for the holidays for the first time and has been on a winter break from his northwest suburban middle school, giving him ample time to spend with family.

Oh, and he's starring in one of the world's biggest TV shows.

Jake is a new cast member in the fifth and last season of "Stranger Things." The supernatural Netflix series set in the 1980s, which concluded with a final two-hour



Jake Connelly, 13, of Arlington Heights, got the call he was going to star in the final season of "Stranger Things" in the middle of a tornado warning. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

episode Wednesday night, has captivated viewers for the past decade, garnering a steadfast following with its retro callbacks and horror-infused science fiction flair.

Jake plays Derek Turnbow this season, a loudmouth bully-turned-unlikely hero.

He fits right in with the series' long-tenured cast, but fans have especially taken a liking to the local newcomer, relishing in his painstakingly endearing performance.

Turn to Actor, Page 2

Bears' playoff seed in their own hands

With a win Sunday afternoon over the Lions, the Bears will lock up the No. 2 seed in the NFC and a home game against the rival Packers. We break down what to watch for this weekend with playoff scenarios in play and quarterback Caleb Williams nearing several milestones. **Chicago Sports**

Hoosiers all business as Oregon looms

Curt Cignetti's perpetual seriousness has become a big part of the Indiana coach's burgeoning lore. He showed a small smile on the podium as IU celebrated its Rose Bowl win Thursday, but minutes later, he was back to business, focused on a semifinal rematch with Oregon. **Chicago Sports**

Trump issues threat to Iran

US is 'locked and loaded' if any demonstrators are killed in protests, president warns

By Jon Gambrell
Associated Press

DUBAI, United Arab Emirates — President Donald Trump and top Iranian officials exchanged dueling threats Friday as widening protests swept across parts of the Islamic Republic, further escalating tensions between the countries after America bombed Iranian nuclear sites in June.

At least seven people have been killed so far in violence surrounding the demonstrations, which were sparked in part by the collapse of Iran's rial currency but have increasingly seen crowds chanting anti-government slogans.

The protests, now in their sixth day, have become the biggest in Iran since 2022, when the death of 22-year-old Mahsa Amini in police custody triggered nationwide demonstrations. However, the demonstrations have yet to be countrywide and have not been as intense as those surrounding the death of Amini, who was detained over not wearing her hijab, or headscarf, to the liking of authorities.

Trump initially wrote on his Truth Social platform, warning Iran that if it "violently kills peaceful protesters," the United States "will come to their rescue."

"We are locked and loaded and ready to go," Trump wrote, without elaborating.

Shortly after, Ali Larijani, a former parliament speaker who serves as the secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council, alleged on the social platform X that Israel and the U.S. were stoking the demonstrations. He offered no evidence to support the allegation, which Iranian officials have repeatedly made when protests sweep the country.

Turn to Iran, Page 6

Prosecutors tie South Side gang faction to 14 slayings

By Sam Charles
Chicago Tribune

Federal and state prosecutors now say a single gang faction on Chicago's South Side committed 14 murders and shot at least 18 other people in just two years as part of a brazen crime spree meant to tighten the group's grip on the West Chatham neighborhood.

From March 2019 through April 2021, authorities say, members and associates of Faceworld — a faction of the Gangster Disciples — used stolen cars to track down rival gang members, sometimes targeting funerals and memorial services.

The faction — whose territory is bounded by 79th Street, 83rd Street, Vincennes Avenue and State Street — also carried out several armed robberies, a home invasion and sexual assault, and trafficked cocaine and heroin in Illinois and Iowa, prosecutors allege.

"The defendants and other Faceworld members and associates used threats and intimidation to prevent victims and witnesses from cooperating with law enforcement," the U.S. attorney's office in Chicago said in a statement last week. "Faceworld members allegedly promoted their violent enterprise on social media, posting comments, photos, and videos to proclaim membership in the gang, taunt rivals, and boast about murders and other acts of violence."

Turn to Gang, Page 4

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 29 Low 15

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 8

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
178th year No. 3 © Chicago Tribune

